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INTERVIEW / CEO

"LISTENING TO THE CONSUMER IS CRITICAL"

Frederique Constant CEO, Niels Eggerding, on refining an icon, the surprise breakout success of the Manchette, and the uncomfortable truth about who really cares about in-house movements.

Niels Eggerding has been at the helm of Frederique Constant for 14 years—long enough to watch the brand grow from a niche, accessible-complications maker into one with genuine collector credibility. At Watches & Wonders 2026, he sat down to discuss two very different new arrivals: the updated Classic Worldtimer, refined after a decade-plus in the collection, and the Manchette, a bracelet watch that has quietly become one of the brand's biggest hits in recent memory. The conversation ranged from design philosophy to the uncomfortable truth about who really cares about in-house movements.

The new Classic Worldtimer feels like a serious evolution—a smaller case, the new FC-719 movement, and a significantly longer power reserve. What was the brief for this update?

The Worldtimer has been in the collection for 14 years. It's one of our most iconic and best-selling calibres, so updating it is always a bit scary. Before doing anything, I asked my team to analyse feedback across all social media platforms. I didn't want ten points—I asked for the top three. Three things clearly came out: the case diameter felt too large, the date disc overlapped the city disc and affected legibility, and the power reserve needed improvement.

So the brief was clear: keep it iconic: It should be recognisable as a Frederique Constant from a distance; bring something new, and fix those three key issues. That's exactly what the team delivered. We downsized the case, resolved the visual conflict on the dial, and increased the power reserve from 38 to 72 hours; almost a 90% improvement.

For me personally, listening to the consumer is critical. Every evening, I go through feedback myself on social media. Even negative comments matter, because they tell you exactly where to improve.

Removing the date cleans up the dial considerably. Was that a difficult decision, given how functional the Worldtimer has traditionally been?

For me, it was actually quite clear. We are not replacing the existing Worldtimer; we are evolving the collection. The 42mm version with the date will continue, and over time we may upgrade it as well. The new 40mm version without the date gives us a cleaner, more refined alternative. So now you have two options—a more traditional, functional version with the date, and a cleaner, more design-focussed version without it. They can coexist. It wasn't really a conflict; it was about offering a better balance within the range.



The Manchette feels very design-led, almost like jewellery (image above)**. Is this a conscious effort to explore a more expressive side of Frederique Constant?**

Yes and no. The Manchette has actually been in the collection for over 20 years, so it's not new to us. But the way we approached it this time was very intentional. Timing was key. There's a strong return of vintage bracelet designs —something brands like Cartier and Piaget have historically dominated. But those pieces are often inaccessible at our price point. We saw that opportunity and moved very quickly. The development took just seven months, which is extremely fast for us.

The result? It's probably the biggest hit I've seen in my 14 years with the brand. It brings in a younger audience, adds a different energy to the collection, and complements